Notably, these agreements are initiated and signed by IO staff without the direct oversight of member states, granting IOs autonomy in broadening their informational networks. This autonomy allows IOs to circumvent potential interference by powerful stakeholders, who may be unaware of the extent to which data shared with one IO are subsequently disseminated to others. By formalizing these arrangements, IOs can address critical informational gaps while maintaining their operational independence.

To empirically investigate these dynamics, we utilize a unique dataset from Clark (2021) on information-sharing agreements in the development sector, covering the period from 1956 (when multiple IOs first began operating in the space) to 2018.[13] These data capture agreements that were signed between twenty-eight development IOs, including prominent regional banks such as the African Development Bank and the Asian Development Bank. Our primary analysis focuses on the years 1990 to 2018 because information-sharing agreements are most prevalent during this period.

The development sector provides fertile ground for studying information sharing. First, despite being characterized as ripe for competition among IOs in the literature (Lipscy 2015, 2017), it exhibits high levels of interorganizational cooperation.[14] This cooperation persists across decades, as information-sharing agreements are rarely revoked once established. Second, information collection and dissemination are central to the mandates of most development IOs. For instance, the World Bank collects raw data for constructing influential datasets like the World Development Indicators, which inform global decision making across economic, health, and environmental domains. A senior official from a regional development bank affirmed this mandate, noting that member states are expected to provide statistics when requested.[15]

Development is representative of many economic issue areas in terms of the sensitivity of the information collected and shared by IOs. Therefore, development does not constitute an easy case for information sharing, and we anticipate that our argument generalizes to other economic IOs as well.

Development IOs vary widely in their propensity to sign information-sharing agreements. Figure 4.1 visualizes the evolution of information-sharing networks among development IOs, revealing that while collaboration is widespread, it is pursued unevenly. Some newer organizations, like the AIIB, have quickly become prolific participants in